

THE KEY

Written by
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INT. HARDWARE SHOP - MORNING

A narrow shop crowded with paint tins, coils of rope and glass jars of screws. SAMIR (68), the owner, stands behind a scarred wooden counter in a GREY CARDIGAN. A brass KEY hangs on a string from a nail beside the till.

His son ARUN (36) enters with a thick folder under his arm. He does not say good morning.

ARUN
Papa, the buyer has agreed to the price. He wants an answer by Friday.

SAMIR
The shop is not something you answer by Friday.

ARUN
It loses money every month. You know this. The ledger knows this.

Samir runs a finger along the counter, as if checking for dust.

SAMIR
Your grandfather opened this door at six every morning for forty years.

ARUN
And he died in a chair in the back room, still waiting for customers.

The words hang in the air. Samir turns to the shelves and begins straightening jars that are already straight.

SAMIR
(quietly)
Leave the folder on the counter.

Arun sets it down. Samir does not touch it.

CUT TO:

EXT. SHOP FRONT - DAY

Sunlight on a dusty street. LEELA (64), Samir's wife, sweeps the pavement with a short broom. Her daughter MIRA (33) coasts up on a bicycle and drops the kickstand.

MIRA

MIRA (CONT'D)
Ma, you should not be sweeping in
this heat.

LEELA
Someone has to. Your father will
not sit down and your brother will
not stand still.

Mira laughs and pulls up the heavy steel shutter. It jams halfway. She forces it and the rusted edge slices across her left hand.

MIRA
Ah!

Leela drops the broom and catches her daughter's wrist. She presses the end of her sari against the wound.

LEELA
This shutter has been broken for
ten years. Ten years I have said
it.

MIRA
Ma, it is only a scratch.

LEELA
Everything in that shop is only a
scratch, until it is not.

CUT TO:

INT. FAMILY KITCHEN - EVENING

A small kitchen, warm and loud with pans. PRIYA (34), Arun's wife, ladles lentils into steel bowls. Mira sits at the table with a clean white bandage on her left hand and Leela beside her. Arun leans in the doorway. Samir's chair is empty.

PRIYA
Your father said he was only going
to close the till.

LEELA
That was two hours ago.

ARUN
He is punishing me by not eating.

MIRA
(dry)

MIRA (CONT'D)
He is not thinking about you at
all, Arun. That is what hurts.

Priya sets a bowl in front of Mira and looks at the bandage.

PRIYA
Does it hurt?

MIRA
Only when someone brings up the
shop.

Leela pushes a bowl toward the empty chair, then pulls it
back. Nobody speaks. The clock over the stove ticks.

CUT TO:

INT. LAWYER'S OFFICE - DAY

A cramped office lined with green files. MR. DESAI (55), the
family lawyer, sits behind a desk stacked with papers.
Across from him Samir sits stiffly, now in a BLUE SHIRT, his
hands folded on his knees. The brass KEY lies on the desk
between them.

DESAI
You understand that once you sign,
the shop is no longer yours to open
in the morning.

SAMIR
I understand better than my son
does.

DESAI
And you do not wish him to be
present?

SAMIR
He has already decided what this
day means. I would like to see if I
have.

Desai turns the paper around and offers a pen. Samir looks
at it for a long moment.

SAMIR (CONT'D)
Read me the last clause again.

DESAI
"The key to the premises passes to
the person named below, on the day
of signing."

SAMIR
And the person named below?

Desai slides a second sheet across the desk. Samir reads the name. His face changes.

CUT TO:

INT. HARDWARE SHOP - NIGHT

The shop is dark except for the light over the till. Arun stands at the counter turning the pages of the old ledger, page after page of his grandfather's handwriting. The folder lies unopened beside him.

The door opens. Samir enters, still in the blue shirt, and puts the brass KEY in Arun's hand.

ARUN
Papa, what is this?

SAMIR
The lawyer says it belongs to you now. He did not say it belongs to the buyer.

ARUN
You named me?

SAMIR
I named the only person who has ever read the ledger to the end.

Arun looks down at the key, then at the nail beside the till where it used to hang. He hangs it there, and it swings a little, and settles.